

FIELD GUIDE / VOL. 01 • MAY 2026

Two coworkers, one *engine*.

A side-by-side look at Anthropic's Claude Cowork and Microsoft's Copilot Cowork — what's actually different, what's the same, and which one fits the job in front of you.



vs.



BROUGHT TO YOU BY



01 THE TL;DR

Same engine. Different *chassis*.

CLAUDE COWORK

The original.

Faster updates, lower price, friendly to non-Microsoft tools and developers.
Anthropic's own product.

COPILOT COWORK

The enterprise repackaging.

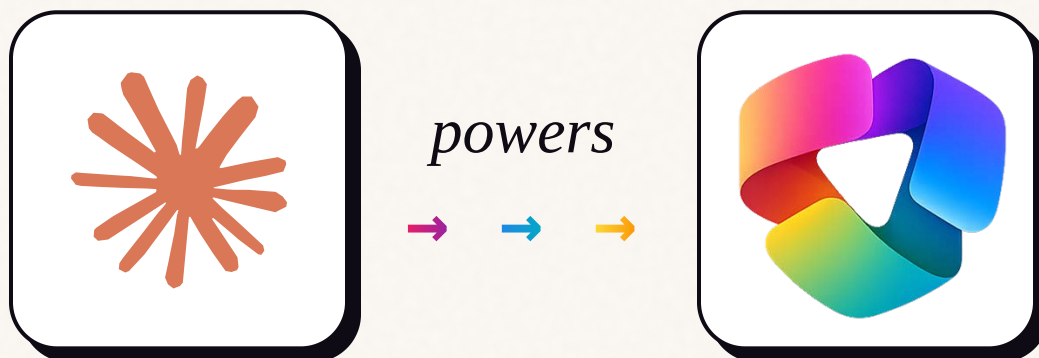
Cloud-native, no desktop required,
deeply tied into Outlook, Teams, and
SharePoint. Microsoft's M365 wrapper.

Copilot Cowork is built on Claude Cowork's agentic engine, licensed by Microsoft and wrapped in M365's security and governance.

02 THE ANTHROPIC CONNECTION

They're directly *related*.

Microsoft licensed Anthropic's agentic architecture under a multi-year compute partnership. Same engine — different chassis.



THE DEAL

\$30 Billion

Azure compute partnership · late 2025

CONFIRMED BY

Jared Spataro

Microsoft CMO · launch announcement

03 ACCESS & INSTALLATION

Where does it *live*?



Claude Cowork

ANTHROPIC • DESKTOP

DESKTOP APP

Required. Cowork only runs inside the Claude Desktop app. App must be open, machine awake.

PLATFORMS

Mac and Windows desktop. Mobile can dispatch if paired with a running desktop.

PRICING

Included in **Pro \$20/mo**, Max, Team, Enterprise. **Generally available.**



Copilot Cowork

MICROSOFT • M365 CLOUD

◆ EDGE

DESKTOP APP

Not required. Runs entirely in Microsoft's cloud. Browser, Teams, or Outlook — no install.

PLATFORMS

Anywhere M365 reaches. True cross-device, no machine anchor.

PRICING

Included with **M365 Copilot Business \$21**, **M365 Copilot \$30**, or **M365 E7 \$99** /user/mo. **Expected GA May 2026.**



04 DATA ACCESS & MEMORY

What can it *see*?



Claude Cowork

ANTHROPIC · DESKTOP

DATA SOURCES

Local files (per-folder consent), web via Claude in Chrome, connectors for Drive, Gmail, Slack, MCP servers.

WORK CONTEXT

Projects with persistent instructions, folder-level context, cross-session memory. Flexible.

REACH BEYOND THE ECOSYSTEM

✓ Strong. Built for mixed toolchains.



Copilot Cowork

MICROSOFT · M365 CLOUD

◆ EDGE

DATA SOURCES

Full Microsoft Graph — Outlook, Teams, SharePoint, Excel, Calendar, OneDrive — all live, all native.

WORK CONTEXT

Work IQ models your relationships, threads, and meeting history to ground tasks in real job context.

REACH BEYOND THE ECOSYSTEM

~ M365-centric. Limited to Microsoft.

05 TASK EXECUTION

Where does work *actually* run?



Claude Cowork

ANTHROPIC · DESKTOP

WHERE TASKS RUN

Isolated VM on your local machine. Shell, file edits, code execution. **Desktop must be on.**

SCHEDULED TASKS

✓ Via /schedule. Needs desktop running at execution time.

MULTI-STEP COORDINATION

Subtasks, parallel workstreams, plugin extensibility, file delivery to local disk.



Copilot Cowork

MICROSOFT · M365 CLOUD

◆ EDGE

WHERE TASKS RUN

Microsoft cloud, 24/7. Plan → checkpoint → approve → execute. Runs whether your laptop is on or off.

SCHEDULED TASKS

✓ Cloud-side. Runs regardless of your machine state.

MULTI-STEP COORDINATION

Same engine + M365 orchestration: deck in PowerPoint → Calendar → Outlook in one task.



06 SECURITY & GOVERNANCE

Who does *IT* trust?

**Claude Cowork**

ANTHROPIC · DESKTOP

ENTERPRISE CONTROLS

RBAC, group permissions, admin spend limits. GA on Enterprise. Audit logging in progress.

COMPLIANCE CERTIFICATIONS

Standard Anthropic policies. Pro/Team data not used for training.

DATA RESIDENCY

On-device for local tasks. Cloud-hosted for connector tasks.

**Copilot Cowork**

MICROSOFT · M365 CLOUD

◆ EDGE

ENTERPRISE CONTROLS

Full M365 compliance boundary. All actions auditable. Agent 365 governance adds per-agent controls.

COMPLIANCE CERTIFICATIONS

SOC 2, HIPAA-ready via M365. Stays inside your existing tenant boundary.

DATA RESIDENCY

Stays inside your M365 tenant. EU/UK admins must opt in to Anthropic settings.



07 MODEL & CAPABILITY

What's *under the hood*?



Claude Cowork

ANTHROPIC · DESKTOP

◆ EDGE

AI MODEL

Claude (Opus, Sonnet, Haiku). Full model selection. Latest versions **day Anthropic ships**.

BROWSER & LOCAL

✓ Chrome agent, local FS, isolated VM, shell access. Built for developers.

UPDATE PACE

Anthropic ships Cowork features **weekly**.



Copilot Cowork

MICROSOFT · M365 CLOUD

AI MODEL

Claude (confirmed for Cowork) + OpenAI in Researcher. Dual-model critique: one drafts, the other reviews.

BROWSER & LOCAL

~ SharePoint and OneDrive only. Not built for local dev workflows.

UPDATE PACE

Tied to Microsoft's Wave release cadence. Slower iteration.

08 THE VERDICT · PT. 1

Pick *Claude Cowork* if...



Claude Cowork

ANTHROPIC · DESKTOP · FROM \$20/MO

- You're an **individual or small team** and price matters.
- Your stack lives in **Google Workspace, Slack**, or non-Microsoft tools.
- You're a **developer** — local files, code execution, shell access.
- You want **browser automation** across the open web.
- You want **new model versions and features the day they ship**.

09 THE VERDICT · PT. 2

Pick *Copilot Cowork* if...



Copilot Cowork

MICROSOFT · M365 CLOUD · FROM \$30/USER/MO

- Your work life lives in **Outlook, Teams, and SharePoint.**
- You can't or won't keep a **desktop running 24/7.**
- You operate in a **regulated industry** with M365 compliance needs.
- You want **cloud-side execution** that doesn't care about your laptop.
- Your IT team already **trusts the M365 governance boundary.**